



Digital Citizenship

Week 7

& Civic Life Online

Topics in this module:

- Digital citizenship: rights, responsibilities & online civic identity
- Ethics of online activism: doxxing, harassment & cancel culture
- Responsible digital behaviour: boundaries, consent & respect online
- Data privacy basics: what you give away every day
- Online safety: scams, grooming & digital blackmail (awareness)
- Civic trust & technology: how misinformation erodes institutions

Digital Citizenship

Rights · Responsibilities · Online Civic Identity

What we'll cover:

What digital citizenship means · The rights you hold online · The responsibilities that come with them · How your online presence shapes your civic identity

What Is Digital Citizenship?

Digital citizenship is the responsible, ethical, and empowered use of technology and the internet to participate in society. Just as physical citizenship comes with rights and duties, so does our life online.

RIGHTS

Right to access

Everyone should have fair access to the internet and digital tools — digital exclusion is a form of civic exclusion.

Right to privacy

You have a right to control your personal data and protect your digital identity from surveillance or exploitation.

Right to free expression

You can speak, organise, and advocate online — subject to the same ethical limits as offline speech.

RESPONSIBILITIES

Verify before sharing

You are responsible for the information you spread. Sharing false content, even unknowingly, causes real harm.

Respect others online

The same standards of dignity and respect that apply offline apply online — anonymity does not remove your ethical duty.

Protect your community

Report harmful content, support those being harassed, and don't be a bystander in digital spaces.

CIVIC IDENTITY

Your digital footprint

Everything you post, share, or 'like' contributes to your public civic identity. It shapes how others perceive your values.

Online as civic space

Social media, forums, and comment sections are modern public squares — spaces for debate, organising, and collective action.

Consistency matters

Strong civic identity means behaving consistently online and offline — not having a 'keyboard persona' that contradicts your values.

Ethics of Online Activism

Doxxing · Harassment · Cancel Culture · Anonymity

The internet gives everyone a megaphone. The question is: how do you use it responsibly?

Online activism has opened powerful new pathways for change — but also introduced new ways to harm, silence, and abuse. This module explores where ethical lines fall.

Doxxing and Online Harassment

DOXXING

Definition:

Publicly publishing private information about someone without consent — home address, phone number, workplace, family details — with the intent to expose or harm.

Why people justify it

Sometimes framed as 'holding the powerful accountable' — exposing corrupt officials, racists, or abusers. The line between accountability journalism and dangerous exposure is real and important.

Why it is still harmful

Once private info is public, you cannot control what others do with it. People have lost jobs, received death threats, been physically attacked, or had their families targeted.

Is it illegal?

In many countries, yes — depending on intent and harm caused. In Pakistan and globally, laws around harassment and privacy increasingly cover doxxing. Ethical activists never doxx.

ONLINE HARASSMENT

Definition:

Repeated, targeted harmful behaviour online — threatening messages, coordinated pile-ons, sexualised abuse, stalking, impersonation — intended to intimidate, silence, or harm.

Who is most targeted?

Women, minorities, journalists, and anyone who challenges powerful figures online face disproportionately high rates of harassment — chilling free expression.

The 'mob effect'

Even when individuals feel their small comment is harmless, pile-ons accumulate into overwhelming abuse. Participation makes you complicit, even if you didn't start it.

What responsible action looks like

Disagree with arguments, not people. Criticise public roles, not private lives. Do not participate in coordinated attacks, even against people whose views you oppose.

Cancel Culture & Anonymity Online

Cancel Culture

'Cancellation' refers to the withdrawal of public support from a person or organisation following revelations of harmful behaviour. Social media has made this faster, louder, and more permanent.

Arguments in favour

- ▶ Holds powerful people accountable when institutions fail to act
- ▶ Gives voice to survivors and marginalised communities
- ▶ Creates social consequences for genuine harm

Arguments against / concerns

- ▶ Can be disproportionate — destroying careers over old or minor offences
- ▶ Denies due process and the possibility of rehabilitation
- ▶ Mob dynamics can amplify false accusations

Key question: Is this accountability or punishment without due process?

Anonymity Online

Anonymity means being online without your real identity attached. It is both a tool of liberation and a cover for harm.

When anonymity is protective

Whistleblowers, activists under authoritarian regimes, abuse survivors — anonymity keeps people safe and enables crucial speech.

When anonymity enables harm

The same shield that protects a dissident can protect an abuser. Anonymity removes the social consequences that keep behaviour in check.

Pseudonymity vs true anonymity

Pseudonyms (a consistent fake name) allow accountability within communities. True anonymity (no name, new account each time) offers no accountability at all.

Ethical principle

Ask yourself: would I say this with my name attached? If not, that is a signal to reconsider the content — not to hide it behind a fake account.

Responsible Digital Behaviour

Boundaries · Consent · Respect Online

Being online does not suspend your ethical obligations. The same principles of respect, consent, and dignity that apply in person apply in every digital interaction.

Boundaries, Consent & Respect in Digital Spaces

DIGITAL CONSENT

Sharing other people's content

Always consider whether someone would be comfortable with you sharing their photo, message, or personal story — even if it was shared with you directly or posted publicly.

Screenshots and private messages

Screenshotting and sharing private conversations without permission is a serious breach of trust and, in some cases, illegal. 'It was just a DM' is not an excuse.

Tagging people in posts

Not everyone wants to be publicly tagged in political, sensitive, or identifying content. Ask before you tag.

DIGITAL BOUNDARIES

Respecting others' online space

Repeatedly messaging someone who hasn't responded, joining conversations uninvited to argue, or following someone across platforms are forms of digital boundary violation.

Group chats and online communities

Online communities — even private ones — have norms and boundaries. Entering to provoke, dump stress on others, or demand attention is disrespectful.

Your own digital boundaries

You have the right to block, mute, or leave conversations. You do not owe anyone unlimited access to your time or emotional energy online.

RESPECT & TONE

Disinhibition effect

Research shows people behave more aggressively online than they would face-to-face. The screen creates false distance — but the harm felt by real people is not distant.

Punching vs. disagreeing

Engaging with someone's argument is legitimate. Attacking their character, intelligence, family, or background because you disagree is not. Know the difference.

Cultural and linguistic context

Sarcasm, humour, and directness don't always translate across cultures online. Consider how your message might be received by someone from a different background.

Rule of thumb: Would you say or do this if the person were standing right in front of you?

Data Privacy Basics for Citizens

What You Give Away Every Day

Your data is the product. When a service is free, you are paying with your information — your habits, preferences, location, and relationships.

Understanding this is not about paranoia — it is about making informed choices as a citizen in a data-driven world.

What Data You Share Daily — Without Realising It

LOCATION DATA

- ▶ GPS coordinates every time your phone or an app accesses location
- ▶ Cell tower triangulation even with GPS off
- ▶ Check-ins, tagged photos, local search queries
- ▶ Used to map your daily routine, relationships, and movements

SOCIAL DATA

- ▶ Who you message, how often, and about what
- ▶ Who you're friends with and their demographics
- ▶ What events you attend or show interest in
- ▶ Used to infer your political views, religious beliefs, relationships

BEHAVIOURAL DATA

- ▶ How long you hover over a post before scrolling past
- ▶ What you search, click, and how long you read
- ▶ Purchase history, browsing patterns, time of day
- ▶ Used to build a detailed psychological and consumer profile

DEVICE & IDENTITY DATA

- ▶ Device IDs, browser fingerprints, IP address
- ▶ Camera and microphone access permissions
- ▶ App permissions (contacts, calendar, camera)
- ▶ Linked to you even when you're 'logged out'

You are not the customer — you are the product. Your data is sold to advertisers, political campaigns, and data brokers.

Practical Data Privacy: What You Can Do

01

Review app permissions

Go to your phone's settings and check which apps have access to your camera, microphone, location, and contacts. Remove permissions you don't actively need.

02

Read privacy settings — not just T&Cs

You won't read 50-page terms. But you can spend 5 minutes adjusting privacy settings on social media. Turn off ad tracking, location history, and 'share with partners'.

03

Use strong, unique passwords

Reusing passwords means one breach exposes everything. Use a password manager (Bitwarden, 1Password) and enable two-factor authentication on all important accounts.

04

Be careful about 'free' quizzes and tools

Personality quizzes, 'which character are you?' apps, and free PDF tools often harvest your data or login credentials. If it's free and asking for permissions, ask why.

05

Know your rights under data law

In Pakistan, the Personal Data Protection Bill outlines your rights. Globally, the EU's GDPR is a model. You can request to see, correct, or delete your data from many platforms.

06

Think before you share

Once data is shared — a photo, your location, a confession in a group chat — you lose control of it. Pause before posting anything you wouldn't want permanently public.

Online Safety

Scams · Grooming · Digital Blackmail (Awareness Level)

This module covers awareness-level knowledge of serious online harms — not to frighten you, but to ensure you can recognise warning signs, protect yourself, and know where to get help.

These issues affect people across all ages, genders, and backgrounds — including university students.

Online Scams and Grooming: Recognising the Warning Signs

ONLINE SCAMS

Phishing

Fake emails or messages that mimic banks, universities, or government bodies. They ask you to 'verify' your login — then steal your credentials. Check the sender's actual email address.

Romance scams

A fake online relationship built over weeks or months, ending in requests for money ('I'm in an emergency'). Increasingly common on all platforms including LinkedIn.

Job / scholarship scams

Fake offers that require you to pay a 'registration fee' first. Legitimate jobs and scholarships never ask you to pay to apply or claim your award.

Impersonation scams

Someone pretending to be a family member in distress, a government official, or a customer service agent. Always verify through a separate channel before acting.

ONLINE GROOMING

What is grooming?

Grooming is when a person builds a manipulative, often secretive relationship — usually with a younger or vulnerable person — to gain their trust before exploiting them emotionally, financially, or sexually.

Warning signs:

- ▶ They are unusually attentive and make you feel uniquely special very quickly
- ▶ They try to isolate you from friends and family ('they don't understand you like I do')
- ▶ They push conversations to private channels away from public platforms
- ▶ They ask for personal photos or information and may ask you to keep the relationship secret
- ▶ The relationship feels exciting but also uncomfortable — trust that discomfort

If something feels wrong, it probably is. Talk to someone you trust. You are never at fault for being targeted.

Digital Blackmail: Sextortion and Cyber-Extortion

Digital blackmail (or 'sextortion') occurs when someone threatens to share private, intimate, or embarrassing content — images, messages, information — unless you pay money or comply with their demands. It is a crime in most jurisdictions.

How it typically happens

Fake romantic connections

A trusting relationship is built, the victim is convinced to share intimate images, then payment or compliance is demanded to prevent their release.

Hacked accounts

Private photos or messages are stolen from cloud storage, emails, or messaging apps through phishing or weak passwords.

AI-generated content

Perpetrators now use AI to create fake intimate images from public photos — then threaten to release them.

What to do if it happens

Do not pay

Paying almost never stops the threat — it signals you will pay again. The perpetrator has no incentive to stop once you comply.

Do not delete the evidence

Screenshot and save all communications — this is evidence. Do not block the perpetrator until after you have done this.

Report to authorities

Pakistan: FIA Cybercrime Wing (helpline: 9911). Internationally: StopNCII.org and NCMEC can help remove content from platforms.

Important to understand

You are the victim, not the perpetrator

Sharing intimate content with someone you trust is not wrong. The wrongdoing belongs entirely to the person who weaponises it.

It affects all genders

Sextortion is particularly common among university-age people. You are not alone and it is absolutely not your fault.

Talk to someone

The shame perpetrators rely on is what silences victims. A trusted friend, counsellor, or helpline is always the right move.

Civic Trust & Technology

How Misinformation Erodes Institutions

Democracy depends on a shared understanding of facts. When technology allows false information to spread faster than truth, it doesn't just mislead — it corrodes the trust that holds civic life together.

Understanding Misinformation: Types and How It Spreads

MISINFORMATION

Definition:

False information shared without harmful intent. The person sharing it genuinely believes it is true.

Example:

Sharing a debunked home remedy because your family always believed it.

Intent: None — but harm is still caused by the spread.

DISINFORMATION

Definition:

Deliberately false or manipulated information, created and spread with the intent to deceive and cause harm.

Example:

A political party creating fake news articles about an opponent's corruption.

Intent: Deliberate deception — this is propaganda.

MALINFORMATION

Definition:

True information used maliciously — taken out of context or weaponised to harm a person or institution.

Example:

Sharing a decade-old quote from a politician to falsely suggest their current position.

Intent: The information is real, but the framing is designed to mislead.

Why does misinformation spread faster than truth?

Emotional content travels faster

Outrage, fear, and disgust trigger sharing instincts. Platforms reward engagement — and false, emotional content generates more engagement than calm corrections.

Algorithms amplify virality

Social media algorithms show you what you'll engage with, not what is true. This creates 'filter bubbles' where misleading content circulates among believers unchallenged.

Corrections rarely reach the same people

A false post may reach 100,000 people. The correction reaches 3,000 — and only some of those are the same people. The lie sticks.

How Misinformation Erodes Democratic Institutions

Elections & Voting

False claims about election fraud, voter manipulation, or candidate misconduct — spread at scale — erode citizens' belief in electoral integrity. When people stop trusting election results, democracy itself is weakened. This has happened in the US (2020), Brazil (2022), and Pakistan (2024 elections saw significant digital rumour campaigns).

Public Health

During COVID-19, misinformation about vaccines, treatments, and the origins of the virus led people to reject life-saving measures. When citizens distrust public health institutions, disease spreads faster and more people die. This is not theoretical — it is documented.

Judiciary & Rule of Law

When courts are portrayed as corrupt, biased, or illegitimate through viral misinformation campaigns, citizens stop seeking legal recourse and may turn to extrajudicial action. This weakens the entire rule of law.

Media & Journalism

Consistent labelling of accurate reporting as 'fake news' erodes the public's ability to use credible information to hold power to account. When no source is trusted, the loudest voice wins — regardless of truth.

Misinformation does not just mislead individuals — it dismantles the shared reality democracies depend on.

Your Role: Critical Thinking and Responsible Sharing

The SIFT Method: Stop · Investigate the source · Find better coverage · Trace claims to the original source.
A simple 4-step habit for evaluating information before sharing it.

How to spot misinformation

Check the source URL carefully

Misinformation sites often use URLs that look like real news outlets (e.g. ABCnews.com.co instead of ABCnews.com). Look at the actual domain.

Search for independent corroboration

If a story is real and significant, multiple credible sources will cover it. If only one obscure site has it, treat it with extreme scepticism.

Reverse image search photos

Many viral 'news' photos are recycled from unrelated events years earlier. Right-click → 'Search image' on Google or use TinEye.com.

Check the date

Old events are frequently recirculated as if they are happening now. A real event from 5 years ago shared today can be deeply misleading.

Civic responsibility in the information age

Pause before sharing

The emotional impulse to immediately share outrage-inducing content is exactly what spreads misinformation. A 30-second pause to verify changes everything.

Share corrections — kindly

If you see a family member or friend sharing false content, correct it gently and share the correct source. Shaming people makes them defensive; kindness makes them listen.

Prebunking > debunking

Warning people about common manipulation techniques (before they encounter specific false content) is more effective than fact-checking after they already believe it.

Use fact-checking resources

Pakistan: Soch Fact Check (sochfactcheck.com).
International: Snopes, FactCheck.org, AFP Fact Check, Reuters Fact Check. Use them — it takes 60 seconds.

Key Takeaways: What You Should Know

01**Digital citizenship has real rights and duties**

Your right to access, privacy, and expression online comes with responsibilities: verify before sharing, respect others, and protect your community.

02**Online activism must remain ethical**

Doxxing and harassment are never justified tools, even against people you oppose. Anonymity does not suspend your ethical duties.

03**Consent and respect apply in digital spaces**

Do not share others' content, screenshots, or personal information without permission. Treat others online as you would face-to-face.

04**You are giving away data constantly**

Your location, behaviour, relationships, and identity are harvested daily. Review your permissions, use strong passwords, and know your data rights.

05**Know how to recognise and respond to online threats**

Scams, grooming, and digital blackmail are real and widespread. Warning signs exist – and support is available. You are never at fault for being targeted.

06**Misinformation erodes democracy**

False information undermines elections, public health, and civic trust. Use the SIFT method. Check facts before sharing. Democracy depends on informed citizens.